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INTRODUCTION

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Introduction: ‘Affiliative Fashion, Relational Analysis and Power’

ABSTRACT

This Special Issue introduction reflects on the tendency, in fashion studies, to focus on fashion and dress mainly as forms of personal expression. We argue that, to counter this trend, fashion studies needs to orient itself to fashion and dress as primarily relational domains, which affiliate wearers and makers with other people, networks and institutions and implicate dress in flows of power. This will enable fashion studies to better realize its aims of equity and decolonization. The introduction offers some examples of the ways that fashion and dress are affiliative practices, at levels ranging from the intimate to the transnational, and describes how the articles gathered in the Special Issue illuminate fashion’s relational qualities.

KEYWORDS

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What does fashion studies need right now? On the precipice of global disasters – political, ecological and military – how can fashion scholars and practitioners reimagine and assert its relevance? This Special Issue was born of a conviction that what is called for is a renewed attention to the mutuality of being, to dress as an affiliative form, one that emerges from, produces and sustains relations of myriad sorts between and among humans and the non-human. This is a question of perspective, of emphasis; fashion studies broadly has provided a host of accounts of dress as relational. And yet, there is a disproportionate weight on narratives of fashion as individual technologies of empowerment. Most often these emerge from the laudable goal of diversifying and decolonizing fashion, of describing and theorizing its actual and potential connections to social justice. What repeatedly seems to recede, however, are the collectivist politics of the movements – feminist, queer, anti-ableist, anti-racist and decolonial – that underpin the move to transform fashion and fashion studies. In assembling this collection of articles, we aim to refocus attention on the many and varied ways that fashion implicates subjects in relation.

As we note above, fashion studies already gives us tools to discern this relatedness, at scales ranging from the personal to the transnational. Consider, for example, the material encounter of the body with garments or accessories, described by a range of scholars including Ellen Sampson (2022), Lucia Ruggerone (2017), Karen de Perthuis (2016) and Stella North (2016). Such accounts stress the power of garments to change the subject. As Peter Stallybrass (1993) notoriously described, when he wore his deceased friend and collaborator's sports jacket to give a presentation, he was immobilized and could not speak; he cried. And he was spurred to what was, for him, an entirely new area of research, one that occupied him for years. In a sense, what he and others who explore this micro-level of embodied interaction with dress point to is the porousness of personhood, the fallacy of the model of individual boundedness and self-possession that animates the post-Enlightenment episteme. The narration of their experiences with dress thus helps to orient us to the potential of wearing to open us onto otherness in concrete ways.

Such work is echoed by analyses of second-hand, previously worn, and disused clothes, which trace the uncanny ways that used garments hold traces of prior wearers and even display agentic capacities (Marshik 2016; Sampson 2023; Mundigo-Moore 2024). Not only is the self in relation with their dress, these studies show, but the wearer's power is sometimes superseded by another. Such work challenges the common account of a self who feels individuated and empowered by the experience of their clothing; the uncanny feeling of being inhabited by another shows that the experience of porous selfhood is not an abstract, theoretical concept but an embodied, affective experience.

The relational quality of fashion is also in evidence as we move from interactions with garments to the garment as a key node in relations among humans (and sometimes the non-human). As has been recognized since at least Georg Simmel (1904), fashion is deeply ambiguous: it is about both marking out one's individuality and signalling affiliation. As fashion is discussed in popular discourse, we propose that this tension is receding in favour of an emphasis on its uses in individual self-determination – too few accounts explore how people use it to navigate their relations to other people, groups and even institutions and ideologies. Wearing clothing is a bid for recognition, whether as part of a group or as distinct from it. And sometimes it is also an intentional courting of misrecognition (e.g. Findlay 2023; Bancroft 2012)

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or an attempt to signify to others in multiple ways at once (Cole 2000; Rault 2011). In any case, a wearer dresses for a gaze, with the knowledge that they will be read. They may fear the gaze or they may knowingly seek to defy it. These options are particularly acute for non-normative people – those, for instance, who are gender-non-conforming or fat or racially marked as threatening when they wear particular things, such as a black man wearing a hoodie (Rand 2017; Nguyen 2015). The navigation of the gaze, then, is the navigation of relations; this is not only about the wearer and the looker but also triangulates them in a much broader context of power relations, which adds complexity to the relation at the centre. It asks that we grapple with a networked sense of relation; rather than an interface between two people, getting dressed is thus more accurately described as a node in a power-saturated relational field, one that includes complexly material or immaterial forces, such as ideology.

We see this, too, in the ways that acquiring clothing plays out. Retail spaces can be deeply alienating for people who do not fit various gendered, raced body ideals (Parkins and Findlay 2023; Reddy-Best and Pedersen 2015; Colls 2006). In these cases, feelings of unease can involve anticipated reactions of interlocutors or actual interactions with retail staff and other customers. The example of the retail environment allows us to see how human interactions are nested within a broader system, in this case one conditioned by the exigencies of profit accumulation. It is a mistake to imagine that the relational quality of fashion is limited to human interactions; fashion/dress is an excellent means of showing how those interfaces bear and are structured by a further field of power that has material implications. Buying and selling or feeling unable to do so, connects subjects directly to the structure of capital, and interactions in this retail space just form the context for actors' emplacement within a global system.

This networked quality of fashion is not limited to wearing and consumption, of course. It is also evident in production. As has been amply documented by scores of activists as well as scholars, the organization of garment production – whereby the labour of making clothes is generally poorly paid and dangerous – can lead to a profoundly inequitable relationship between precariously positioned garment workers and relatively affluent consumers from other parts of the world who buy those clothes (Siddiqui 2009; Hatcher 2019). Consumption ties production and producers in uneven ways, distributing power and privilege asymmetrically among them. And, as work on immaterial production in fashion shows, such affiliations are not limited to the material production of garments in factories, workshops and sweatshops. The production of beauty (Mears 2011), glamour (Wissinger 2015) and value (Mensitieri 2020), among other ineffable qualities, also brings differentially situated actors into contact with one another: models with photographers and viewing publics, for example, and luxury brand employees with wealthy clients.

Other fashion realms also involve transnational relations. The burgeoning of digital media has accelerated the circulation of dress and fashion beyond borders, resulting in frictions and hybrid forms in everything from fashion shows to online retailing to everyday practices (Hauser 2019; Cruz 2016; Gökariksel and Secor 2013; Purdy 2019; Fung 2021). All of these travels involve encounters – of people, garments, ideas and ideologies. Such meetings accentuate the sense of constant transformation that is at the heart of fashion – it is the ubiquity of relation that conditions fashion's changeability,

furnishing its unique character. Focusing on relation, thus, is a means of 'staying close' to the form itself to uncover its specific affordances.

Indeed, we contend that there is much to be gleaned by foregrounding the many affiliations that fashion produces and sustains. Whereas the focus on individual experiences of fashion can inadvertently confirm perceptions of fashion as a superficial and narcissistic practice, the articles gathered here – six peer-reviewed articles and five 'Open Space' pieces – highlight its significance in broader flows of people, ideas, capital and power.

The six articles included in this Special Issue offer diverse perspectives on affect, relationality and affiliative fashion networks. Ben Barry's 'Crip fashion networks: Dress exchanges, hacks and affirmations in disability communities' explores the ways in which disabled people circumvent industry and commodity systems to engage with fashion through tactics such as clothing swaps and mutual aid. This piece demonstrates how fashion can operate as a mode of 'creativity, survival and collective world-building' (169 in this Special Issue) outside of traditional capitalist structures. In a related critique of power, Maaïke A. van Tienhoven's 'Colonial feelings: An affective encounter with a Toba Batak *ulos* textile' analyses the 'lingering affects of coloniality' (181–96 in this Special Issue) in the context of Dutch colonial history, developing a 'material-affective' (183 in this Special Issue) approach that engages the western white researcher in a decolonial relationship with the textile as object. In "'Vivre l'époque": A relational reading of mood, selfhood and feminist world-making in the work of Sonia Rykiel', Karen Van Godtsenhoven uses mood theory to recontextualize Rykiel's designs within both individual and collective contexts of post-1968 French feminist and cultural politics, arguing that 'notions of belonging and a shared sensitivity can help us to critically look at the shifts taking place in sociocultural moods and in fashions at a specific moment and place in time, such as Rykiel's *démodé*' (198 in this Special Issue), which Van Godtsenhoven characterizes as 'a manifesto of liberation from the rules of fashion history and the industry' (201 in this Special Issue). Using Arjun Appadurai's theories of globalized flows alongside actor network theory, Magali An Berthon examines the dynamics of the Cambodian 'silkscape' in 'Exploring the silkscape: Relationships and materialities of silk production in post-conflict Cambodia (1991–2018)', arguing that the term and concept of *khsae*, which means threads or network in Khmer, can offer a way to think through the relationships between 'materials, makers and wearers' (218 in this Special Issue). In 'The networked mediation of fashion rental', Lindsay Parker uses Bourdieu's field theory to analyse 'relational practices among both human and non-human actors' (239 in this Special Issue), arguing that fashion rental 'requalifies rented garments as sustainable by virtue of being shared' (239 in this Special Issue). Finally, in 'Dress-led: Recognizing the affiliative quality of dress as a research framework', Emily J. Oertling and Alyssa C. Opishinski explore continuities between research methodologies that are 'dress-led' in their respective projects: the documentation of dress practices in a Tz'utujil Maya municipality in the Guatemalan Highlands (Oertling) and a material culture analysis of five late eighteenth- and early nineteenth-century European and Euro-American gowns (Opishinski).

The 'Open Space' section of this Special Issue presents five pieces offering shorter meditations on theory and methodology as well as multimedia content. Aurélie Van de Peer's 'First notes on the relevance of resonance theory for fashion studies' explores the possibilities of resonance as 'a relational

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process encompassing both phenomenological and cognitive dimensions, wherein a subject engages with the world, another subject, or a non-human entity in a state of heightened vitality and aliveness' (277 in this Special Issue) to counteract issues of inequality and overconsumption in relations with garments and the fashion industry. Kenya Lee Gutteridge's audio essay 'Glamour: Reflections, refractions and the ghost of the modern woman' offers a reflection on the role of postfeminism in conceptions of modern femininity and selfhood. Alicja Raciniewska integrates a discussion of affiliative fashion and its relationship to metaphor in 'The bonding and socializing role of fashion: The Polish case', exploring connections between partners and relatives. Sophie Oliver's visual essay 'From the Bahamas to a bolero on Bank St: Zora Neale Hurston and historicity' examines Hurston's clothed body as an embodiment of her philosophy of history, using web-based digital tools for multimedia storytelling. Finally, in 'Non-visual approaches to fashion studies', Mikko Kukkonen centres visually impaired people and their relationship to 'fashion as sensorial experience' (301 in this Special Issue), underscoring the haptic and aural as alternative modes of relation. By employing a relational lens, as the articles gathered here do in varying ways, we are able to map the uneven distribution of power through dress and fashion. In doing so, we can make a case for the centrality of fashion to the wider world.

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